born at the right time. I grew up and went to work during the most sustained, spectacular boom in economic history. That boom continues, in spite of the debt crisis, government deficits, competition from Japan, and shortages of Cabbage Patch dolls.

According to the Census Bureau, as reported in the January 1987 *Journal of Accountancy,* the U.S. standard of living has doubled in the past thirty-five years. We work less and less to earn our goods and services. On average we now earn enough in six minutes to buy a dozen eggs, down from thirteen minutes in 1960. We earn enough in two hours to buy a toaster, down from six hours in 1960. We earn enough in seventeen minutes to buy a six-pack of beer, down from thirty minutes in 1960.

Those are averages. Many of us earn more than the average. In a decade or two we may earn enough to keep us in eggs, toasters, and beer for the rest of our lives. Not to mention plane tickets, hotels, personal computers, hair spray, and microwave popcorn that butters itself.

Our new wealth means we have more options than ever before. Many people choose to ignore those options. They stay on the job, pushing the accelerator as hard as ever. They want to live on $500 a day, not $50 a day. They echo John L. Lewis's cry for "More, *More, MORE!*" They already have a pile. But they figure another pile wouldn't hurt.

Many others choose to downscale. Srully Blotnick, in *Ambitious Men: Their Drives, Dreams, and Delusions* (The Viking Press, 1987), reports that almost 40 percent of successful men make a midlife switch to lower-level careers. According to Blotnick, those men tend to enjoy their new careers. They long for their old jobs about as much as a West Texas Bible preacher longs to march in San Francisco's Polk Street Halloween parade.

Still others choose to retire. According to an October 13, 1986, *New York Times* article by Steven Greenhouse, the Bureau of Labor Statistics reports that one in three men aged